

INTO THE FOREST
A view of the sprawling Panna tiger reserve in Madhya Pradesh

ISFR 2021

FOREST COVER-UP

By Rahul Noronha

In a country where the environment versus development debate plays on loop, the biennial India State of Forest Report (ISFR) 2021, released by the Union minister for environment, forests and climate change Bhupendra Yadav on January 13, should have been cause for much cheer. Going by its content, India has increased its forest cover by 1,540 sq. km over the previous assessment in 2019. "The focus of the Narendra Modi government is not just to conserve the forests quantitatively but to enrich them qualitatively," said an upbeat Yadav, while releasing the report.

But look between the covers of the report, the 17th edition of the exercise, and you find some deft green jugglery. Broadly, India's forest and tree cover is 809,000 sq. km or 24.62 per cent of the country's geographical area. A third of the net 1,540 sq. km increase in forest cover comes from a 501 sq. km addition to the very dense forests (VDF) or the best 'quality' forests even as the moderately dense forests (MDF) sees a decline of 1,582 sq. km and the open forests (OF) boast an addition of 2,621 sq. kms over the past two years. The report includes, for the first time, the status of forests in tiger reserves, tiger corridors and lion conservation areas.

In addition, the increase in the OF category is courtesy plantations of fast-growing tree varieties. And monoculture-based plantations (growing a single variety of vegetation) are not exactly the best replacement for biologically diverse natural forests, say experts. "Monocultures lead to site degradation, reduction in moisture content and drop in seed production," says Ravindra N. Saxena, former principal chief conservator of forests, Madhya Pradesh. But he does concede that at least plantations are adding to the tree cover and that "something is better than nothing". Dr Madhu Verma, chief economist, World Resources Institute, though, finds it difficult to ignore the environmental cost of monoculture plantations. "Such plantations lead to loss of resilience in forests, which manifests as trees becoming more susceptible to climate change, diseases and even forest fires. So, while